



ZEST

VARIANT HUMAN · BARD 1 · COLLEGE OF ELOQUENCE AT 3

Background Criminal
Alignment Neutral Good
Proficiency +2 Speed 30 ft

STR

−1

8

DEX

+3

16

CON

+2

14

INT

+0

10

WIS

+0

10

CHA

+3

16

COMBAT

AC

14

HP

10

INIT

+3

HIT DICE 1D8

DEATH SAVES

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SAVING THROWS

Strength −1

• Dexterity +5

Constitution +2

Intelligence +0

Wisdom +0

• Charisma +5

SKILLS

• Deception CHA +5

• Stealth DEX +5

• Persuasion CHA +5

• Sleight of Hand DEX +5

• Investigation INT +2

• Perception WIS +2

Acrobatics +3

Intimidation +3

Performance +3

Arcana / Insight +0

Athletics −1

PASSIVE PERCEPTION

12

ATTACKS

Rapier finesse +5 1d8+3

Hand crossbow 30/120 +5 1d6+3

Dagger thrown 20/60 +5 1d4+3

SPELLCASTING — CHARISMA

SAVE DC

13

ATK BONUS

+5

1ST-LEVEL SLOTS

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BARDIC INSPIRATION — D6

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CANTRIPS

Vicious Mockery 1d4 psychic + disadvantage on its next attack

Minor Illusion sound or image, 30 ft, 1 min

Mage Hand feat no V/S components, can be invisible

1ST LEVEL KNOWN

Dissonant Whispers 3d6, WIS, target flees on its reaction

Faerie Fire 20 ft cube, DEX, advantage vs targets

Sleep 5d8 HP pool, no save, unconscious

Healing Word bonus action, 60 ft, 1d4+3

FEATURES

Bardic Inspiration Bonus action, 60 ft. Ally adds 1d6 to one attack, check, or save within 10 min. 3 per long rest.

Telekinetic feat Bonus action, 30 ft, STR save DC 13 or moved 5 ft toward or away from you.

Criminal Contact A reliable contact in the criminal underworld who can pass messages.

EQUIPMENT

Leather armor worn

Rapier · Dagger · Hand crossbow, 20 bolts

Lute spellcasting focus

Thieves' tools proficient

Crowbar · dark hooded clothes

Entertainer's pack · belt pouch

TRAP KIT

Ball bearings ×1 1 gp

Caltrops ×2 2 gp

Hunting trap ×1 5 gp

Oil flask ×3 3 sp

Remaining 6 gp 7 sp

PERSONALITY

TRAIT

I learn your name and I use it. Every single time. Especially right before you have to do something hard.

IDEAL

Nobody rides the bench. Not the party, not the barkeep, not the goblin who is clearly having a rough week.

BOND

I came up picking locks and picking pockets. The people who pulled me out never asked for a thing back. I'm paying it forward until we're square, which is never, which is the point.

FLAW

I will absolutely talk to the thing we are supposed to be sneaking past.

HOW TO PLAY HIM

Zest is not a con man pretending to be nice. The warmth is *real* and the traps are *real* — that is the whole character. He believes in people out loud, at volume, until it's embarrassing and then a little past that. He has also already worked out which way the door opens.

SPELLS

Vicious Mockery

Enchantment cantrip • 1 action • 60 ft • V • Instantaneous

Target must succeed on a **Wisdom saving throw** or take **1d4 psychic damage** and have **disadvantage on the next attack roll** it makes before the end of its next turn. It must be able to hear you, though it need not understand you.

Minor Illusion

Illusion cantrip • 1 action • 30 ft • S, M (fleece) • 1 minute

Create a sound or an image of an object. A creature that uses its action to examine it can identify it as false with an **Intelligence (Investigation) check against your spell save DC**.

Dissonant Whispers **SIGNATURE**

1st • 1 action • 60 ft • V • Instantaneous

Target makes a **Wisdom saving throw**. On a failure it takes **3d6 psychic damage** and must immediately **use its reaction, if available, to move as far as its speed allows away from you**. On a success, half damage and no movement.

READ THE FINE PRINT

“The creature doesn’t move into *obviously* dangerous ground, such as a fire or a pit.” This will not shove someone into a visible bonfire. It **will** shove them into a trap they don’t know about — which is every trap Zest sets. Hidden hazards only.

Faerie Fire

1st • 1 action • 60 ft • V • Concentration, up to 1 min

20-foot cube. Creatures failing a **Dexterity saving throw** are outlined in light. **Any attack roll against an affected creature has advantage** if the attacker can see it, and it **can’t benefit from being invisible**.

Sleep

1st • 1 action • 90 ft • V, S, M • 1 minute

Roll **5d8** — the total HP of creatures affected, within 20 ft of a point, in **ascending order of current hit points**. Each falls **unconscious** until the spell ends, it takes damage, or someone uses an action to wake it. **No saving throw**. Undead and charm-immune creatures are unaffected.

Healing Word

1st • 1 bonus action • 60 ft • V • Instantaneous

One creature you can see regains **1d4 + 3** hit points. No effect on undead or constructs.

TRAP KIT — RULES

Oil flask 1 sp	Target covered in oil takes an extra 5 fire damage from any fire damage within 1 minute.
Ball bearings 1 gp	Action to cover a 10 ft square. DC 10 Dex or fall prone .
Caltrops 1 gp	Action to cover a 5 ft square. DC 15 Dex or stop moving and take 1 piercing.
Hunting trap 5 gp	DC 13 Dex or 1d4 piercing and stop moving .

BELIEVE

Give Inspiration	“Hey. <i>Hey</i> . Look at me. You’ve done harder things than this before breakfast.”
They fail anyway	“Be a goldfish. Ten second memory. Next one’s yours.”
Healing Word	“Nope. Not today. Not you. Up you get.”
Any NPC	Get their name. Use it twice. Ask one thing unrelated to the quest.

BE CURIOUS, NOT JUDGMENTAL

Don’t say “I search the room.” Ask what’s *out of place*, what’s been *moved*, who lit the lamp, and “what does my character know about this?” — the best question in the game.

TURN ORDER

1. **Bonus action first**. Bardic Inspiration, or Telekinetic shove if spent.
2. **Action**. Round one is Faerie Fire or Sleep, never an attack.
3. **Movement**. Stay 30–60 ft back. Ten hit points.
4. **Reaction**. None at level 1. Unsettling Words from level 3.

INSPIRATION IS SPENT LATE, NOT EARLY

“The creature can wait until after it rolls the d20 before deciding to use the Bardic Inspiration die, but must decide before the DM says whether the roll succeeds or fails.” Hand the die out **proactively**; they choose after seeing the roll.

OPENING MOVE

3+ weak enemies	Sleep . No save.
One big enemy	Faerie Fire .
Enemy near a hazard	Dissonant Whispers .
Ally about to attack	Bardic Inspiration .
Ally at 0 HP	Healing Word (bonus action).
Out of slots	Vicious Mockery .

COMBOS

1 — OIL, THEN FIRE

Throw an oil flask (1 sp), have anyone with a torch or fire cantrip hit it. **+5 fire damage** for one silver piece.

2 — SLEEP, THEN CRIT

Sleep makes them **unconscious**. Any melee attack within 5 ft of an unconscious creature is an **automatic critical hit**, and it auto-fails STR and DEX saves.

3 — THE BOX

Caltrops on the chokepoint, ball bearings behind it, then Telekinetic shove (bonus action) or Dissonant Whispers to push them back through it. **Place the kit before initiative** or it costs a full action.

LEVEL PLAN

3 Eloquence — Silver Tongue, Unsettling Words
4 ASI → CHA 18, save DC 14
5 Glyph of Warding — the engine
6 Unfailing Inspiration — be a goldfish
7–8 Rogue 1–2 — Sneak Attack, Cunning Action
9 Assassin — auto-crit vs surprised
13 Magical Secrets → Spike Growth, Wall of Force
16 Symbol — 60 ft emplacement

ASK THE DM AT SESSION ZERO

Does a triggered trap make a target **surprised**? Assassinate auto-crits surprised creatures, but by RAW surprise is set at the start of combat by Stealth vs passive Perception. A trap does not automatically confer it, and the back half of this build depends on the answer.

Companion phone reference: [Zest.html](#) — full spell text, trackers, dice.